

Implementation of Key Principles of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) by the Foundation for Polish Science (FNP)

Action Plan

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Information about the Institution

The Foundation for Polish Science (FNP) is a non-governmental, apolitical, non-profit organization dedicated to supporting science. It is the largest non-budgetary source of research funding in Poland. The Foundation achieves its statutory goals by:

- Supporting outstanding scientists and research teams across all fields of science,
- Promoting innovative ventures and the commercialization of scientific discoveries and inventions.

The Foundation has been supporting science since 1991, adapting its activities to the changing needs of the Polish research community and the standards of grant-giving institutions. FNP supports all fields of research, including the humanities, and offers programs to researchers at all career stages, with a focus on critical career moments, such as deciding to continue research after a PhD, forming the first research team, or working towards the

commercialization/implementation of research results. In recent years, the Foundation has also supported the creation of consortia and specialized, world-leading research organizations aimed at achieving scientific excellence and international competitiveness, as well as implementing global best practices in identifying research programs and topics, personnel policies, and managing R&D work and commercialization.

The Foundation actively participates in international cooperation networks like Science Europe, the Regional/Global Research Council, and the Philea Research Forum to exchange experiences and improve research funding practices.

Since 2007, the Foundation has been implementing programs financed by EU structural funds. The Intelligent Development Operational Program, which concluded in 2023, allowed the Foundation to inject PLN 1.2 billion into Polish science. Over 2800 scientists were supported, and 14 independent research units were created. In 2023, the Foundation's annual budget was approximately PLN 243.8 million, with PLN 19.7 million coming from its own funds. From 2023 to 2027, the Foundation is implementing activities financed by the European Funds for a Modern Economy Operational Program.

In 2023, the Foundation joined the European Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) and became one of the signatories of the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment.

Guiding Principles

The main principle of the Foundation's operation is to support scientific excellence, including high-quality research and outstanding researchers. FNP's support is directed directly to scholars and research groups. All grants, awards, and scholarships are awarded through competitions based on the peer-review method, and the quality of research work determines the support allocation. The competitions are based on a bottom-up approach, allowing researchers to propose the topics and methodologies of the projects, in line with their interests, competencies, and research preferences.

In its activities, the Foundation adheres to principles of ethics in scientific activity, integrity, transparency, and social responsibility. The Foundation respects and implements the principles expressed in **the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment**, particularly:

- Ethics and integrity principles,
- Safeguarding academic freedom,
- Ensuring the independence and transparency of data, systems, and criteria for research assessment,
- Focusing evaluation criteria on quality,

- Recognizing contributions to knowledge development and the (potential) impact of research results,
- Acknowledging the diversity of forms and outcomes of research activities,
- Adapting evaluation criteria and processes to the specifics of research disciplines, types of research, and stages of a researcher's career, respecting multi-, inter-, and transdisciplinary research,
- Recognizing the diversity of roles and career paths of researchers, including experience outside academia,
- Ensuring gender equality, equal opportunities, and inclusiveness.

FNP was the first institution in Poland to receive the **HR Excellence** logo in 2012 and has been continuously implementing the principles of the **European Charter for Researchers and the Code of Conduct for the Recruitment of Researchers**.

The Foundation's competition rules are transparently shared with potential participants. The competition procedures are announced in advance and include information on the methods and criteria for selecting projects for funding. Info meetings and detailed information on the FNP website help potential applicants prepare for participation. Applicants receive feedback on the assessment of their projects/applications and have the right to appeal the assessment and funding decisions.

The Foundation actively supports the application of professional ethics by researchers in Poland and participates in developing good practices regarding ethical standards that should apply in Polish scientific institutions. In the form of codes, it defines the principles and values binding its employees, beneficiaries, candidates, and reviewers in its competitions.

FNP places great emphasis on social responsibility, engaging in issues significant to science and science policy, initiating important debates, supporting the exchange of expert knowledge, and inspiring discussions based on scientific knowledge. It strives to disseminate verified, based on scientific achievements knowledge regarding socially significant challenges and ensures that the research it funds has the greatest possible impact on improving the quality of life and society.

The Foundation adheres to principles of equal opportunities and non-discrimination, including gender equality and accessibility for people with disabilities. It opposes all forms of discrimination and works towards a diverse scientific environment. The assessment of applications submitted in FNP competitions takes into account the specificity of individual scientific disciplines and the diversity of applicants' professional experiences.

The Foundation is a learning organization, continuously evaluating its activities to develop and apply the best possible standards. It also aims to help fully utilize their individual abilities and research passions. FNP promotes best practices in recruiting research teams and offers training assistance in scientific supervision of younger researchers and research management.

Challenges and Limitations in the Research Assessment System Reform Process

- **Funding rules for R&D activities from EU structural funds.** The Foundation's programs can be divided into those financed from its own funds (START, FNP PRIZE, MONOGRAPHS, bilateral awards) and those financed from structural funds (from 2023 - from the European Funds for a Modern Economy Operational Program: MAB FENG, PROOF OF CONCEPT, FIRST TEAM FENG, TEAM-NET FENG). While the Foundation has considerable flexibility in implementing programs financed from its own funds, programs financed from structural funds are subject to rigid procedures, and the evaluation and selection system for the projects is governed by the general rules of the implementation act and the Executive Instruction of the Intermediate Body for the European Funds for a Modern Economy 2021-2027 program (i.e., the Ministry of Funds and Regional Policy). These rules are both bureaucratic and ill-suited to the specifics of research projects and the needs of science and the research community. Although the Foundation has managed to reconcile the requirements of the structural funds spending system with good practices and international standards in project evaluation, this is becoming increasingly difficult. The Foundation continuously strives to better align the standards for evaluating research projects under programs financed from structural funds with the best practices in research funding, but its capabilities in this regard are limited. Among the limitations hindering the proper evaluation of grant projects, the following should be mentioned:
 - **The requirement to use the Polish language in applications submitted to FENG competitions.** For over 15 years, the Foundation has used applications in English in its competitions. This was due to both the international standards of conducting science and the principle of openness of FNP competitions to researchers of all nationalities, as well as involving experts from around the world in the assessment of applications, which facilitates avoiding conflicts of interest and increases the impartiality of the assessment. Currently, not wanting to give up quality standards, FNP is trying to find and engage outstanding Polish-origin scholars working abroad who are fluent in Polish for the needs of new competitions. The application assessment process, already complicated in itself, becomes even more difficult administratively because of this;
 - **The rules for selecting experts to evaluate applications in competitions.** Requirements to avoid potential conflicts of interest in assessment of applications in programs funded by structural funds were directly transferred from competitions for representatives of companies seeking public funds and are not adapted to the specifics of the scientific environment. The need to search for (Polish-speaking) experts with appropriate substantive qualifications

and simultaneously meeting the new formal requirements regarding the absence of conflicts of interest significantly slows down the process of evaluating applications in FENG competitions and does not serve its quality;

- **Exclusion of the possibility of using reviews prepared by specialists in narrow fields as auxiliary material for the panel of experts deciding on funding in the competition.** According to the guidelines of the Ministry of Funds and Regional Policy, specialized reviews are discouraged due to possible discrepancies between the reviewer's opinion and the panel's final decision. This approach eliminates discussion and confrontation of opinions from the scientific project evaluation process, which are integral elements of research work verification.
- **Scientific community habits:** The quality of the peer-review process largely depends on habits of researchers, who often refer to bibliometric indicators in their evaluations. The Foundation sensitizes its reviewers and panelists that their evaluation should be qualitative and adapted to the researcher's career stage and the specifics of their research. They are also made aware of the need to avoid stereotypes in assessments.
- **Reviewers' fatigue:** It is increasingly difficult to recruit reviewers and panelists for evaluating competition applications, and multiplying the requirements for them further complicates this task. A contextual and individualized approach to assessing scientific achievements prolongs and complicates the reviewer's work. Additional training/instructions for experts also increase their time commitment. As a result, scientists are increasingly reluctant to participate in the assessment process.
- **Financial and staffing resources:** A more individualized and contextual approach to evaluating applications/projects extends the competition resolution time. It also requires greater staffing and financial resources to ensure competent grant program management and pay reviewers/experts.

Implementation Plan for CoARA Commitments

1. **Recognizing diverse contributions to research development and various research career paths, adapted to the needs and specifics of the research**

Current Practice: The Foundation supports research in all fields, including the humanities, basic and applied research, and the transfer of innovative projects to economic and social practice. Research assessment methods (including criteria, indicators, expert selection) are tailored to the specifics of the projects. FNP evaluates applications in thematic panels, ensuring expert selection suited to the project's characteristics and consistent understanding of the criteria. Evaluators receive detailed instructions on the program and the Foundation's expectations as well as on assessment principles. Depending on the type of

research and program goals, various types of research achievements and contributions to knowledge development are considered.

Further Actions: Clarifying the understanding of scientific excellence, research quality, and originality in the criteria for evaluating applications/projects.

2. Basing research evaluation on qualitative methods, particularly reviews, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators

Current Practice: All FNP research assessment processes are strictly based on qualitative criteria. The most important evaluation criterion is quality, including the originality of the evaluated scientific achievements. Bibliometric indicators are never the assessment determinant.

Further Actions: Further sensitizing experts involved in applications/projects assessment to the need for qualitative assessment and great caution in using quantitative indicators.

3. Avoiding improper use of bibliometric indicators in research evaluation, especially Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index

Current Practice: FNP is a signatory of the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA), advocating that the quality and impact of scientific achievements, not bibliometric parameters like Impact Factor, should be the basis for a researcher's evaluation. Bibliometric indicators, especially Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index, are not used in evaluations.

Further Actions: Continuing to inform experts involved in applications/projects assessment about FNP's non-use of bibliometric indicators, especially Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index in assessing researchers' achievements.

4. Avoiding the use of research organization rankings in research evaluation

Current Practice:

- In all of the Foundation's programs, the application assessment process is strictly based on qualitative criteria.
- The most important evaluation criterion in FNP competitions is quality, including the originality of research achievements.
- Rankings of research organizations are not taken into account in the evaluation of research projects or researchers' accomplishments.

Further Actions: The current practice does not require changes.

5. Ensuring resources for the reform of scientific research evaluation, if necessary, to achieve the intended organizational changes

Current Practice:

- The Foundation participates in international cooperation networks, including workshops and discussions aimed at improving project evaluation principles (Science Europe, Philea Research Forum).
- The application assessment process in the Foundation undergoes regular internal evaluation, and there is a unit responsible for this task within the FNP organizational structure.
- The application evaluation process in the Foundation within programs funded by structural funds also undergoes external evaluation.

Further Actions: Increasing the involvement of the Foundation's employees in international cooperation networks, including participation in workshops and discussions aimed at improving project evaluation principles.

6. Review and development of criteria, tools, and processes for research evaluation

Current Practice

The research project evaluation process is subject to continuous analysis and periodic evaluation. Evaluation procedures for projects within competitions, as well as during and after their implementation, are constantly monitored and updated to better address the challenges associated with this evaluation.

Further Actions: Further careful analysis of the procedures and criteria of applications/projects assessment.

7. Raising awareness about research evaluation reform and ensuring transparent communication, guidelines, and training on evaluation criteria and processes, as well as their use

Current Practice

- Information about CoARA is available on the FNP website.
- The Foundation is engaged in discussions on the reform of the science system in Poland and the preparation of this reform project, which includes a reference to CoARA.
- The Foundation is involved in the CoARA Polish National Chapter, participates in discussions conducted within PL-NC, and coordinates the sub-team for research project evaluation.

Further Actions:

- Increasing FNP employees' knowledge about CoARA activities and other initiatives for research evaluation reform.

- Updating the FNP website with new information about CoARA activities and other initiatives for research evaluation reform.

8. Exchange of practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and outside the Coalition

Current Practice

- The Foundation participates in CoARA working groups (Working Group on the assessment of research proposals; Working Group on Societal Impacts).
- The Foundation is involved in the CoARA Polish National Chapter, participates in discussions conducted within PL-NC, and coordinates the sub-team for research project evaluation.
- The Foundation actively participates in discussions and exchanges experiences within the Philea Research Forum and Science Europe (e.g., Working Group on Research Culture; Working Group on Open Science).

Further Actions

- Increasing engagement in CoARA working groups.
- Promoting recommendations developed within CoARA working groups on the FNP website and in FNP informational materials, as well as in national community discussions in which FNP participates.

9. Informing about the progress in adhering to the Principles and implementing the Commitments Publication of “Action Plan: Implementing the Core Commitments”

Current Practice: Publication of the document: *Implementation of Key Principles of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) by the Foundation for Polish Science (FNP). Action Plan.*

Further Actions

- Periodic updates on progress in implementing the Coalition's principles.
- Exchange of experiences within the CoARA Polish National Chapter.

10. Evaluation of practices, criteria, and tools based on evidence and the latest scientific research, and sharing information openly for data collection and research purposes

Current Practice

- The process of selecting research projects for funding is subject to continuous internal analysis and periodic evaluation.

- External evaluation of the project selection process conducted by the Ministry of Funds and Regional Policy (responsible for the expenditure of structural funds).

Further Actions: Further analysis and evaluation of the process of selecting research projects for funding.